elites who disregard the will of the people. By questioning IOs' credibility, populists discredit the very foundations of their operations.

In more aggressive cases, populists may spread misinformation about IOs to sow public mistrust. They can amplify conspiracy theories suggesting that IOs operate against national interests or secretly conspire with global elites—extreme examples of scapegoating (Handlin, Kaya, and Günaydin 2023). Highlighting perceived failures while conveniently ignoring successes allows populists to paint IOs as ineffective or even harmful. By exploiting gaps in public understanding and promoting sensationalized narratives, they can erode domestic support for international cooperation.

This strategy is particularly appealing to populists because it allows them to control the narrative. They position themselves as defenders of sovereignty and champions of ordinary citizens while casting IOs as tools by and for a disconnected elite (Copelovitch and Pevehouse 2019). Even when IO initiatives demonstrably benefit a country, populists may frame those benefits as accruing only to domestic elites, or may take credit for generating the benefits themselves, further undermining IOs' legitimacy.

For IOs, the consequences of this information warfare can be dire. Without reliable input from member states, IOs face challenges in achieving their mandates. When their credibility is publicly tarnished, they may struggle to rebuild trust, even if a populist leader is eventually replaced. IOs thus face incentives to ensure the reliable transmission of key data and documents from member states.

2.2.6 Co-optation

Populists don't just challenge IOs from the outside—they can infiltrate and corrupt them from within, reshaping their objectives to serve their own interests. Co-optation occurs when populist leaders strategically appoint loyalists or like-minded individuals to key positions within IOs, effectively steering these institutions away from their original mandates, or use their influence over IOs to do so themselves. This strategy, while sometimes subtle and difficult to detect when it occurs, can erode IOs' foundations and compromise their legitimacy.